EXODUS 34:7

"Pilot"

by

Cristina da Luz

cristiinadaluz@gmail.com
(617) 820- 1645

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TEASER

OVER BLACK:

VOICE
Mercedes--

FADE IN:

INT. MERCEDES' ROOM - PAST - NIGHT

SUPER: 2007

YOUNG MERCEDES (10, curious, stubborn, and altruistic) GASPS as she opens her eyes.

She HASTILY sits and scans the room. It's pitch black.

Young Mercedes rubs her eyes, adjusting them to the darkness.

MERCEDES
...Carlos?

She waits for a response. Nothing.

MERCEDES (CONT'D)
Carlos, this is not fun--

The door CREAKS open.

MERCEDES (CONT'D)
Who's--

BANG! The door BURSTS open and SLAMS into the wall.

Young Mercedes JUMPS up. She stares at it, but no one stands outside.

VOICE (O.C.)
Mercedes.

Young Mercedes fights her tears.

MERCEDES
Wh- who's there?

The door steadily starts to close again, when...

BANG! BANG! BANG! It CRASHES against the wall multiple times.

Young Mercedes JOLTS out of bed. The door stops.

VOICE
Mercedes.

Hesitantly, young Mercedes marches to it. The door gently opens for her.

INT. HOTEL HALLWAY - PAST - CONTINUOUS

In the darkness, young Mercedes swings along the hallway. She can hear herself breathing.

INT. HOTEL STAIRS TO THE BACKYARD - CONTINUOUS

The door to the backyard SQUEAKS as it opens and closes with the blow of the wind. Young Mercedes is mesmerized by it.

The Voice whispers from outside.

VOICE (O.C.)
Mercedes.

Young Mercedes ambles to it in a trance.

YOUNG ALBERTO (15, sarcastic and stoic) STUMBLES inside. He looks agitated and breathes heavily.

He JUMPS back when he sees Mercedes.

ALBERTO
What the hell are you doing?

Beat.

ALBERTO (CONT'D)
...Mercedes?

VOICE (O.C.)
Mercedes.

Young Mercedes stares past young Alberto outside.

MERCEDES
Did you hear that?

ALBERTO
What?

Young Alberto looks back outside, and then back at young Mercedes.

ALBERTO (CONT'D)
I don't have time for this...

Young Alberto rushes past her and disappears into the darkness.

Young Mercedes looks at the door and continues her way...

EXT. HOTEL'S BACKYARD - PAST - CONTINUOUS

Outside. The night is moonless and serene. In its silence, only crickets can be heard.

Young Mercedes stops and gazes at a wooden cabin about twenty meters away from her. She frowns. The lights of the cabin are on.

She paces toward it. As she gets closer, the calming silence gets replaced by indistinct voices. Those belong to a WOMAN and a MAN.

Now standing in front of it, young Mercedes tries for the cabin's door.

It opens. She looks surprised.

She takes a moment before stepping in.

INT. WOODEN CABIN - PAST - CONTINUOUS

Young Mercedes examines her surroundings. The cabin is stuffed with construction and gardening tools.

Her attention quickly turns to the source of light. It comes from a basement.

The voices are now clearer, but only the woman can be heard. It sounds like muffled screams.

As young Mercedes wanders to the basement door, the noises get louder and louder. Suddenly...

A SHADOW SPRINTS from downstairs. It's YOUNG CARLOS (6, spontaneous and easygoing).

He almost FALLS back when he sees young Mercedes.

MERCEDES
Carlos? I knew it was you!

Young Carlos shushes her. There is fear in his eyes.

CARLOS
We can’t be here, Dad’s gonna be upset.

He grabs young Mercedes’s hand and guides her outside. She takes one last look at the basement before following her brother.

INT. MERCEDES’ ROOM - PAST - NIGHT

Young Mercedes lays on her bed, staring at the ceiling. Her eyes start to give in when...

VOICE (O.C.)
(Louder than ever) MERCEDES!

The voice now comes from the patio.

Shaking, young Mercedes slowly makes her way to the window. She looks outside.

A WOMAN wearing a RED DRESS stands with her back turned to young Mercedes. As she feels young Mercedes’ gaze upon her, she slowly starts to turn.

Young Mercedes’ face turns from curiosity to despair.

She SCREAMS!!!

The woman’s skin is gray and swollen. Her red eyes stare deeply into Mercedes’ with a longing expression.

Leisurely, her disfigured face forces a toothless smile.

CUT TO:

INT. MERCEDES’ APARTMENT - RHODE ISLAND - DAY

KNOCK! KNOCK! KNOCK!

Mercedes (now 27) JOLTS awake.

SUPER: 2024

She bewilderedly scans her surroundings. She’s in the middle of the living room.

Piles of clothes gather on the couch, which is the only piece of furniture in the area. Leftovers, unpacked boxes, and unopened letters fill the rest of the space.

KNOCK! KNOCK! KNOCK!

The knocking turns her attention to the apartment's door.

MERCEDES
Who's there?

FINN (O.S.)
It's me.

MERCEDES
(beneath her breath) Fuck.

Mercedes speeds to the door. She clumsily unlocks the three different locks, revealing FINN (27).

She pokes her head outside while pulling the door behind her as much as possible, hiding the mess inside.

MERCEDES (CONT'D)
Finn, you're early.

FINN
Actually, you're late.

Finn glimpses inside the apartment.

FINN (CONT'D)
Is everything ok in there?

MERCEDES
Yup, just give me a minute.

He tries to take one last look inside, but Mercedes quickly shuts the door.

INT. FINN'S CAR - DAY

Mercedes rides shotgun. The breeze blows in her hair as she looks out of the window, avoiding eye contact with Finn.

FINN
It's not healthy to live like that
you know?

MERCEDES
Relax, I just moved in.

FINN
You moved in six months ago.

BUZZ-- Her phone starts vibrating. She looks at who's calling: 'Rómina'. She frowns.

FINN (CONT'D)
I just don't want you to let yourself go again.

MERCEDES
What do you mean by that?

FINN
You know what I mean.

MERCEDES
No, I don't actually--

BUZZ-- She hangs up, angrily.

MERCEDES (CONT'D)
And why do YOU care anyway...

Long beat.

FINN
I wouldn't be here if I didn't.

She looks out of the window again.

INT. THERAPY ROOM - DAY

Mercedes lays on an orange couch. The room is minimally decorated, except for the eccentric postmodern paintings hanging on the wall.

LAURA (40S), her therapist, sits in front of her with a notebook in her hands.

LAURA
And when did they start again?

MERCEDES
On Monday. I woke up and I was on the stairwell of my building.

LAURA
Were you dreaming about her again?

Mercedes nods.

LAURA (CONT'D)
Did you tell anyone about this? Finn?

MERCEDES
No, I don't wanna worry him with this again. It'll just make him feel like he has to do something. That he has to save me.

LAURA
I'm sure you're not bothering him--

Mercedes breaks down, crying.

MERCEDES
I was doing so well Laura, why does this keep happening? Every time I get my shit together she comes back and it all crumbles down.

Beat.

MERCEDES (CONT'D)
Sorry--

LAURA
Don't apologize.

MERCEDES
How do I make it stop?

LAURA
You already took the first step which was coming back to your sessions. From now on, we'll work on it together, ok?

MERCEDES
Yeah.

The two smile at each other.

EXT. PARKING LOT - DAY

Finn leans against his car while he smokes. His gaze is distant. He hears footsteps approaching him.

He looks back and sees Mercedes. He immediately throws the cigarette to the floor and steps on it.

MERCEDES
Do you smoke now?

FINN
I don’t smoke. I just smoked. First time.

MERCEDES
I thought you despised smoking.

FINN
I do. This was stupid. I just bought it.

Finn takes out a pack of newly bought cigarettes and shows it to Mercedes. He walks to a trash can and throws it away.

FINN (CONT’D)
See?

This causes Mercedes to giggle.

FINN (CONT’D)
What?

MERCEDES
Nothing.

FINN
How was it?

MERCEDES
It went well.

FINN
Yeah? How many times per week?

MERCEDES
Don’t worry, I can commute.

FINN
What? No! I’ll drive you.

Mercedes looks at him, longingly.

FINN (CONT’D)
What? I’m happy to. I don’t have much going on anyways

Mercedes interrupts him with a hug. He seems surprised but slowly hugs her back.

BUZZ-- it's Mercedes's phone again.

Mercedes takes it out. "Rómina". She stares at it for a few moments.

FINN (CONT'D)
Who is it?

MERCEDES
Rómina.

Finn frowns. Mercedes takes it.

MERCEDES (CONT'D)
Hello?

CUT TO:

INT. AA MEETING - NEW JERSEY - NIGHT

Alberto (now 32) sits in a circle inside a dimly lit salon. He's amongst people of all ages and genders. The crowd all pays attention to MICHAEL (50s), who sits in the middle.

Alberto's gaze is distant, his mind even more so. Mike's voice becomes clearer and clearer until it finally brings him back to earth.

MIKE
Alberto?

Alberto looks around. Everyone's staring at him.

ALBERTO
Can you repeat that?

MIKE
Wanna share the news with us?

ALBERTO
Uh, yes. Umm... hi everyone. I hope you all are doing fine. I'm personally doing great...

He looks at Mike who nods.

ALBERTO (CONT'D)
I- I've been sober for two years now. Today's my coke divorce anniversary.

People giggle and clap.

ALBERTO (CONT'D)
(Laughs) Thanks, everyone. It has been quite a journey you know. Not easy at all but, so worth it.

Beat.

ALBERTO (CONT'D)
My son actually, is coming to visit in the next cuple of days. I haven't seen him in a year, he lives in Canada now with his mom and stepdad. It'll be the first time he'll visit alone ever since his mom and I divorced so, I'm looking forward to that. The feeling of being able to hang out with him is better than any drug I ever took so...I'm grateful to still be here.

MIKE
Thank you for sharing Alberto. We're all proud of you.

People start indistinguishably chatting with him.

INT. ALBERTO'S CAR - NIGHT

Alberto drives in the drizzle through Boston. The streets are busy, with people dressed in party attire ready to enjoy their Friday night. He observes them, as he passes by, with wishful eyes.

SCREEEECH!

Alberto abruptly HITS the car brake. A WOMAN stands in the middle of the street with her back turned to him only centimeters away from his car.

Alberto composes himself, trying to regulate his breathing. He takes the seatbelt off and prepares to leave the car. But...

The woman is gone. Alberto confusedly looks around before a car behind him HONKS.

He starts his car again. Through the mirror, he sees the woman's silhouette disappearing in one of the streets.

EXT. ALBERTO'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

The living room is small but well-organized. Alberto lays on the sofa illuminated only by the light of the TV. He eats some noodles while he watches "How I Met Your Mother".

TRIM--

His phone starts ringing. He looks to see who it is. "Pam". His face radiates happiness. He takes one last bite of the food before picking it up.

ALBERTO
Hey!

EXT. PAM'S BACKYARD - NIGHT

Pam sits in an armchair covered with a big blanket. Over her, a cloudy night. ROB (late 30s), sits in front of her. They have Alberto on speakerphone.

PAM
Hey Alberto. How's everything?

INTERCUT

ALBERTO
Great. How are you guys?

PAM
We're good. You know, it's starting to get a little cold.

ALBERTO
Same here.

Beat.

ALBERTO (CONT'D)
So? Finishing packing Thomas?

Pain fills Pam's face.

ALBERTO (CONT'D)
Can I talk to him?

PAM
Actually, that's why I'm calling.

ALBERTO
Ok...

PAM
I--

She looks at Rob for help.

ROB
Hey buddy, it's Rob. You're on speakerphone.

ALBERTO
Oh, hey Rob. What--What's going on?

PAM
Rob and I have been talking about Thomas's visit...

ALBERTO
And?

Pam can't say it.

ROB
We don't think it's a good idea.

Beat.

ALBERTO
What?

PAM
It's just too soon, and...we are not comfortable with him going alone. He's only 8--

ALBERTO
He won't be alone, he'll be with me!

PAM
You know what I mean.

ALBERTO
This is ridiculous! We've been planning this for a month now. He's excited to come!

PAM
I'm sorry Alberto...

ALBERTO
No, you're not. Don't fucking pretend you are!

PAM
Not everything is about you. This is about Thomas's well-being.

ALBERTO
He's MY son!

PAM
He's OUR son!

ROB
Take it easy Alberto.

ALBERTO
And who the fuck are you Rob? You're not even his father!

PAM
He's been more of a father to Thomas than you.

This strikes Alberto.

ALBERTO
How do you expect me to be a father when you take him away from me to another country?

Beat.

ALBERTO (CONT'D)
I'm sober you know...

Pam swallows her cry.

ALBERTO (CONT'D)
I've been sober for two years now. I do it all for him. Please, Pam.

PAM
We gotta go, Alberto.

Pam hangs up.

Alberto slowly puts the phone down. He suddenly stands up and kicks the living room table in front of him, knocking it to the floor.

VRRRRRROOOM--

His phone vibrates. He takes a deep breath before grabbing it.

His face changes from frustration to curiosity. "Mercedes".

INT. SAOIRSE LIVING ROOM - DAY

TICK-TOCK, TICK-TOCK...

In the old-fashioned decorated living room sits CARLOS (now 23) and SAOIRSE (60s) in front of him.

Tears fall down Saoirse's eyes. Carlos writes in a notebook. On the table between the two of them, lies an audio recorder which marks "30 minutes" and counting.

CARLOS
And what did they do when you told them about Baldwin's actions toward you?

SAOIRSE
They silently let me go. As they did to all of them.

CARLOS
Did they make you sign anything?

Saoirse nods.

CARLOS (CONT'D)
Do you still have it?

Saoirse grabs a folder next to her and shakily goes through the pages.

TICK-TOCK, TICK-TOCK...

Carlos turns to the wooden clock on the wall. He stares at it as if in a trance.

SAOIRSE (O.C.)
There.

He's SNAPS out of it. Saoirse leads him to a piece of paper. He scans through it.

CARLOS
Do you mind me taking this so I can-
-

SAOIRSE
Oh no, please take it

CARLOS
Thank you.

SAOIRSE
I should be the one taking you Mr.Mendes.

CARLOS
Oh please, that’s my father. Call me Carlos.

Saoirse smiles and stands up.

SAOIRSE
Would you like some tea, Carlos?

Carlos nods and smiles as Saoirse leaves the living room. His gaze turns to the clock again.

TICK-TOCK--

CUT TO:

INT. CARLOS’S APARTMENT - DAY

Carlos steps in only to find his roommates ED (23, loud and funny) and MARTIN (22, intelligent and raw) getting ready to leave.

They both stare at Carlos unimpressed, waiting for him to remember something. He does.

CARLOS
Is it tonight?

ED
Yup.

CARLOS
Fuck!

ED
We literally talked about it yesterday mate.

Carlos walks past them.

MARTIN
He was too busy playing Sherlock.

ED
Again?

CARLOS
Journalist. And yes.

He goes to his room.

ED
Don’t you think that MAYBE, this is going too far?

CARLOS (O.S.)
What? Helping people?

MARTIN
You are not helping people, you are deceiving them...lying basically. Telling them you can do them justice.

Carlos comes out of his room dressed in a suit.

CARLOS
I’m not lying Martin, I’m giving them hope.

MARTIN
Same thing.

CARLOS
And we are close to getting this asshole.

He looks at both of them.

CARLOS (CONT’D)
Ready?

ED
No.

Carlos smiles and taps ED’s back.

INT. HOUSE PARTY - NIGHT

A crowd of about two hundred twenty-something-year-olds gathers in a mansion, all dressed formally.

Carlos prepares a drink on the kitchen’s balcony as an intoxicated MARY (23) stumbles in his direction.

She clumsily tries to serve some whiskey.

CARLOS
Need help with that?

MARY
Yeah, thanks. Carlos right?

Carlos nods. He turns around a starts pouring some water on the cup instead of whiskey.

MARY (CONT'D)
I feel like I just graduated high school, but here I am at a 5-year reunion.

CARLOS
Time flies when you get older.

MARY
You're supposed to become wiser too, but look at me.

Carlos hands her the cup. She drinks it without seeming to notice it's not alcohol.

CARLOS
We're not 25 yet so you should be fine.

Mary giggles.

This calls BILLY's attention. He excuses himself from the group he is with and cruises towards them.

MARY
I guess. I still have time to make some bad decisions.

Billy gets there. Mary rolls her eyes when she sees him.

MARY (CONT'D)
I told you to leave me alone Billy.

Billy turns to Carlos.

BILLY
Did you give her more to drink?

Before Carlos can respond, Billy snatches the drink away from Mary's hand.

MARY
Billy!

CARLOS
What the fuck man?

BILLY
You stay out of this! Let's go Mary.

Billy grabs Mary's arm and the two leave. Carlos observes as they go up and disappear on the second floor.

He hesitates before RUSHING after them.

INT. HOUSE PARTY - 2ND FLOOR HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS

Carlos stumbles on people as he rushes up the stairs. The music in the background grows lower and lower as adrenaline rushes through his brain.

TICK-TOCK, TICK-TOCK--

AAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAH!

A WOMAN'S SCREAM echoes through the hallway.

Carlos RUNS toward it. The SCREAMS are now followed by PUNCH NOISES.

CARLOS
MARY?

CARLOS passes small crowds who stare at him as if he is a manic. He starts opening every door on the floor.

AAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAH!

The SCREAMS grow louder as he gets deeper into the long hallway.

He approaches the last door. LOCKED.

CARLOS (CONT'D)
MARY!

Carlos KICKS the door with all his strength as he...

INT. HOUSE PARTY ROOM - CONTINUOUS

...FALLS into the room. Billy, who kneels next to the bed, looks up at him with a confused look on his face. Mary bends over next to him.

Without thinking any further, Carlos SPRINTS towards Billy and STRIKES him in the face.

Billy FALLS down as Carlos gets on top of him.

BILLY
WHAT THE--

PUNCH!

GASPS can be heard by the small crowd that gathered around the commotion. Mary looks up at them with vomit in the corner of her mouth.

MARY
Carlos?

PUNCH!

MARY (CONT'D)
CARLOS WHAT ARE YOU DOING?

Carlos does not seem to listen. He STRIKES Billy again, who now bleeds through his nose.

MARY (CONT'D)
STOP! He was helping me...PLEASE.

Billy's eyes start to close as Carlos HITS him again. And again, and again--

CUT TO:

EXT. HOUSE PARTY - NIGHT

Carlos sits on the sidewalk. He examines his bloody and bruised knuckles. Martin and ED talk to Billy on the front porch, who holds a bloody cloth on his nose and has a swollen face.

VRRRRRRRR--

Carlos feels his phone vibrating in his pocket. He painfully grabs. "MERCEDES."

EXT. HOTEL'S BACKYARD - PAST-DAY

SUPER: 1997

MARTA (mid-20s, talkative and noisy) plays with BABY ALBERTO (4) in the backyard.

From afar, she sees JOSE (43, charming and confident), coming out of a wooden cabin. He suspiciously looks at both sides before stepping out and closing the door behind him.

MARTA takes this opportunity and rushes towards the cabin, leaving Alberto playing alone.

She cautiously looks in all directions before trying for the door.

Click. It opens.

INT. WOODEN CABIN - PAST - CONTINUOUS

She quickly steps in and closes it behind her. She grabs a piece of iron and starts working on the lock. She periodically glances out of the window to check on Alberto and see if it was clear.

Twik.

Just the noise she wanted to hear. She presses the lock button and tries for the door from outside. It still opens. Bingo. She can’t help but smile.

She quickly steps out and quietly closes the door.

INT/EXT. ALBERTO'S CAR - DAY

Alberto’s lost in his thoughts.

Mercedes steps out of her building carrying a carry-on and a backpack.

He sees her and honks. She shyly waves at him.

INT. ALBERTO'S CAR - MOMENTS LATER

Alberto drives while Mercedes rides shotgun. Some tension can be felt in the air between the siblings. Both struggle to think about something to say.

MERCEDES
How’s Thomas?

ALBERTO
How’s Finn?

MERCEDES (CONT’D)
You go first.

ALBERTO
He’s good.

Beat.

ALBERTO (CONT’D)
I don’t remember if I told you, but he lives in Canada now.

MERCEDES
I didn’t know that.

ALBERTO
Yeah, they had to move for Rob’s job.

MERCEDES
I see. Remind me, how old is he now?

ALBERTO
Seven.

MERCEDES
Wow...time sure flies.

ALBERTO
Yeah...

Awkward silence.

ALBERTO (CONT’D)
I didn’t know you guys moved. Got tired of the city?

MERCEDES
Yeah...

ALBERTO
I thought you loved Providence.

MERCEDES
I do.

ALBERTO
Then why did you move?

MERCEDES
‘Cuz Finn and I broke up.

Alberto looks surprised.

ALBERTO
What? When?

MERCEDES
About a year ago.

Beat.

ALBERTO
Sorry, I...I didn’t know that.

MERCEDES
It’s ok. It wasn’t good for both of us.

Another long pause.

ALBERTO
How did you find out about Dad?

MERCEDES
Rómina called me. Said he passed away the night before.

He bites his lips.

MERCEDES (CONT’D)
I’m sorry. I didn’t ask how you were doing. I know you guys were close...

ALBERTO
Do you know if they ended up getting married?

MERCEDES
Apparently.

Alberto scuffs.

ALBERTO
Of fucking course they did. He probably left her the hotel, like she always wanted.

MERCEDES
You don’t know that.

ALBERTO
Is Carlos coming?

MERCEDES
Yes. After a lot of convincing.

ALBERTO
He hates that place.

MERCEDES
Can you blame him?

The two grow silent again.

EXT. HOTEL - DAY

The Hotel sits at the top of a small Hill in Maine. Its architecture is reminiscent of the one of an old castle painted in brown. The mid-fall scenery gives it an eerie and charming look.

They drive through the property. The once-before majestic garden that surrounds it seems like it hasn't been taken care of in months.

Mercedes spots the lake on the side and nostalgically smirks.

EXT. HOTEL - CONTINUOUS

As the car approaches the small parking lot, the siblings spot RÓMINA (40, rigid and direct) waiting for them at the entrance. She has an emotionless expression on her face.

Alberto parks the car as SAMUEL (60s) walks toward them to help with the luggage. Alberto and Mercedes smile and nod at him before making their way to Rómina.

RÓMINA
Mercedes. Alberto--

Mercedes goes for a quick and comforting hug.

MERCEDES
It's nice to see you, Rómina.

Rómina smiles. Alberto just goes for a handshake.

RÓMINA
I'm sorry for your loss. It's been hard for us too.

SILVIA (6, joyful and playful) comes running out of the hotel, followed by AMBER (late 20s, noisy). She hugs Mercedes, who looks at her, confused. Rómina gives Amber a deadly stare.

MERCEDES
(Kindly) Oh, who do we have here--

RÓMINA
This is Silvia.

Beat.

RÓMINA (CONT'D)
Your little sister.

Silvia lets go of Mercedes and goes to hug Alberto. The two exchange puzzled looks.

INT. KITCHEN - DAY

Mercedes, Alberto, and Rómina have some tea and cookies while Silvia plays happily with Amber in the lobby.

RÓMINA
It all happened so suddenly with Jose. We are all still very much in shock.

MERCEDES
Do they know what happened?

Alberto observes Silvia from afar, clearly bothered.

RÓMINA
They are still determining the cause of death--

ALBERTO
How come we didn’t know we had a sister?

RÓMINA
How could you have known? You were estranged.

ALBERTO
Well, the same way you called us to say that our father died, you could’ve done the same to announce this.

MERCEDES
Alberto...

ALBERTO
What? You don’t think it’s weird that we didn’t know we had a sister? She’s about Thomas’s age for god’s sake.

RÓMINA
If you were interested in your father’s life you could’ve called yourself. Jose would’ve been happy to hear more from you.

ALBERTO
Well, it sure doesn't fucking feel like it.

Alberto stands up.

ALBERTO (CONT'D)
Excuse me.

He rushes out of the kitchen.

EXT. HOTEL - NIGHT

Carlos steps out of the taxi in front of the hotel, carrying a backpack. He examines it, with an anxious look on his face.

The moonless night gives it an even scarier look than before.

GIGGLES echo from the back of the hotel.

This alarms Carlos. As if he can't help himself, he hesitantly follows it...

INT. HOTEL - PAST - NIGHT

Young Carlos wanders alone; in the night's silence, only one sound can be heard...

TICK-TOCK, TICK-TOCK...

The blow of the wind interrupts the clock's rhythm and consequently gets his attention. He follows its howl, which leads him to the open back door.

EXT. HOTEL'S BACKYARD - PAST - NIGHT

Young Carlos steps outside and looks around. From afar, he spots ROSALYN (7), who tries to break into the familiar wooden cabin.

CARLOS
No one is allowed in there.

His sudden presence startles her.

ROSALYN
My mom is inside. I want my mom! I don't like the dark.

Tears roll down her eyes. She sits down and covers her eyes with her hands.

CARLOS
I used to be scared of the dark too, but it's not that bad. It's just the same as it would be during the day, but cooler.

Rosalyn looks up at him.

CARLOS (CONT'D)
Besides, it's more fun to play in the dark.

ROSALYN
Play what?

CARLOS
Hide and seek. You wanna play?

Rosalyn nods frantically, smiling.

EXT. CABIN - NIGHT

Carlos stands in front of the same cabin, which is now falling apart. He walks around it, examining its fragile structure.

CREAK!

CARLOS
Hello?

Silvia lurks behind it.

SILVIA
BOO!

Carlos lets out a SCREAM!

SILVIA's face turns from playful to alarmed. She starts to cry.

CARLOS
(Regretful)Oh, I'm sorry, I--

Rómina comes RUNNING out of the hotel towards them.

RÓMINA
GET AWAY FROM HER!

CARLOS
What?

As she gets closer, she recognizes him.

RÓMINA
Carlos? Oh, I'm sorry, I thought--

CARLOS
That's ok. She just caught me by surprise.

Silvia runs to her mother's arms.

RÓMINA
It's ok Silvia, this is your brother Carlos.

Carlos looks confused. Rómina notices and forces a smile. He forces a smile back.

INT. LIBRARY - NIGHT

Carlos enters the library to find Alberto and Mercedes in silence, both reading something. They don't notice him.

CARLOS
So there are four of us?

Mercedes's face lights up when she sees him. Alberto is not as excited.

MERCEDES
Carlos!

She quickly stands and goes to hug her brother. Alberto drags his feet after her.

CARLOS
Not so tight, my back is killing me after that flight.

Alberto goes for a handshake, but Carlos pulls him in for a hug. He awkwardly hugs back.

CARLOS (CONT'D)
Missed you Alberto.

ALBERTO
Missed you too man.

The three exchange looks.

CARLOS
No seriously, there are four of us?

INT. OUTSIDE THE LIBRARY - SAME TIME

Listening through the ajar door is Rómina, apathetic as always.

SHADOWS hide behind her in the dark hallway. They seem to belong to a group of women, but only their backs are visible. They are all staring at the library's door.

INT. HOTEL - PAST - DAY

SUPER: 2006

Rómina (23) follows LUCIA (60, blunt and sagacious) along the hotel's main hallway. Rómina wanders around, amazed. The high ceilings and wide windows create rays of sunlight that illuminate the place and give it a fairytale-like look.

LUCIA
Ok. We will need you from seven to seven, six days a week as we discussed before--

Jose, comes down the stairs and enters the kitchen. We only see his silhouette, but Rómina gets hypnotized by him.

LUCIA (CONT'D)
Rómina?

RÓMINA
Oh, yes. Yes, I understand.

Lucia analyzes her up and down with a displeased look.

LUCIA
Wait here.

Lucia leaves Rómina alone.

Rómina walks around, looking at old paintings of landscapes, clearly inspired by New England's wilderness.

JOSE (O.C.)
Do you like those?

Rómina jumps up and looks at the stranger. It's Jose. She blushes.

RÓMINA
Yes, they are very pretty.

JOSE
Well thank you, I drew them myself.

RÓMINA
Really? Are you an artist?

JOSE
I wouldn't call myself that but I won't correct you if you do.

Lucia comes rushing down.

LUCIA
Mr.Mendes, I'm so sorry, is she bothering you?

JOSE
Not at all. Miss--

He waits for her to complete.

RÓMINA
Rómina.

JOSE
Rómina and I were having a pleasant conversation about art.

LIGEIA (43, hypnotizing and charismatic) picks out of the kitchen.

LIGEIA
Are you joining us, JOSE?

Ligeia looks at Rómina for a second before parading elegantly to them. She hugs and kisses JOSE.

LIGEIA (CONT'D)
We are waiting for you.

Jose nods and looks at Rómina.

JOSE
It was a pleasure, Miss Rómina. Hope to see you next week.

This upsets Lucia, who silently folds a piece of paper she holds and puts it in her pocket.

The cuple walks back to the kitchen holding hands. Before entering, Ligeia gives Rómina one last intimidating look, before closing the door.

INT. AUTOPSY ROOM - DAY

Mercedes, Alberto, and Carlos stand in front of a covered body. The PATHOLOGIST uncovers it, and their faces turn from deadpan to HORRIFIED.

Jose's body lies there with a BIG BULLET HOLE in his head.

ALBERTO
I can't--

Alberto STORMS OUT of the room.

Carlos just stands there, frozen. He glances at Mercedes and sees tears rolling down her face.

EXT. HOSPITAL - DAY

Mercedes sits on a bench staring at nothing. Carlos stands by her side and Alberto paces back and forth.

ALBERTO
Do you really think it's normal that Rómina didn't tell us that he got shot?

MERCEDES
It was suicide--

ALBERTO
Dad wouldn't kill himself.

MERCEDES
How would you know that?

ALBERTO
I know my dad.

CARLOS
Maybe you didn't know him as well as you think.

This REALLY upsets Alberto.

ALBERTO
And do you?

CARLOS
I'm just saying, neither of us has spoken to him in years. Maybe he was going through something.

ALBERTO
Or maybe Rómina killed him.

Carlos and Mercedes exchange a look of “Here we go again”.

ALBERTO (CONT’D)
Think about it. She hid the fact that he got shot, hid the fact that SILVIA exists, and now finally has the hotel for herself.

CARLOS
Do you hear what you’re saying?

ALBERTO
I know you never cared about him.

Carlos laughs, incredulous.

ALBERTO (CONT’D)
Look at you! You’re not even bothered that Dad has a bullet in his eye!

CARLOS
You’re right, I don’t! But you never cared about him either! Did you try and talk to him after what happened?

Alberto’s meaner changes.

CARLOS (CONT’D)
Now that he’s gone you’re suddenly worried about Rómina keeping the fucking hotel. Just admit that’s what worries you.

Alberto looks at Mercedes for support, but she just looks down.

ALBERTO
Fuck you. Both of you.

He leaves them, frustrated.

INT. WOODEN CABIN - PAST - NIGHT

A silhouette moves in through the dark quickly towards the cabin. It’s Marta.

She peeks inside, but it’s pitch black. She takes a deep breath before trying the door.

It opens. It’s now or never.

INT. WOODEN CABIN - PAST - CONTINUOUS

She quietly closes the door behind her. The silence inside the dark cabin is deafening. Only wooden cracks can be heard.

Marta takes out a lantern and heads down to the basement. With each step, her heartbeat grows louder.

The stairs creek as she goes down. She runs out of steps. Marta hesitates, then turns on the room lights.

She freezes and drops her lantern. She’s horrified, but what she sees is not visible to us.

INT. BAR - DUSK

Alberto sits in a somewhat busy bar for a late afternoon. The bar imitates the town’s mood, old, and gloomy but weirdly cozy.

A WOMAN enters the bar, but we don’t see her face. She scans around the room and rests her eyes on Alberto. She walks toward him.

MARTA
Is it free?

She points at the seat beside him; he nods, and she sits.

MARTA (CONT’D)
I’m Marta.

ALBERTO
Alberto.

A BARTENDER approaches them.

BARTENDER
(To Alberto) What will it be?

ALBERTO
Can I get a Manhattan?

BARTENDER
Right away.

He leaves.

MARTA
Are you sure you wanna do that?

ALBERTO
Excuse me?

MARTA
The drink.

ALBERTO
Why else would I be here?

MARTA
Socialize? You don't seem like the drinking type.

ALBERTO
Well, you don't know me, so.

The bartender comes back with Alberto's drink.

ALBERTO (CONT'D)
Thanks.

Alberto stares at the drink. All of that progress... He hesitates. Marta observes him with curiosity.

He puts the drink aside. Marta smiles.

MARTA
So, socialize?

This makes Alberto smirk. He takes a good look at her for the first time.

ALBERTO
Do I know you?

MARTA
Do I look familiar?

She takes a sip of his drink. He smiles.

INT. CARLOS'S ROOM - NIGHT

Carlos WAKES up. He's sweaty and breathing heavily.

He automatically puts on a jacket and opens his room's door...

EXT. HOTEL - PAST - NIGHT

Young Carlos runs after Rosalyn, who reaches the wall first.

ROSALYN
One, two, three, CARLOS!

Young Carlos falls in defeat, causing Rosalyn to laugh. He laughs along but notices that hers suddenly ceased.

He looks up at her and stops laughing as well. Her fixed gaze crosses him. Her face has turned pale.

CARLOS
Rosalyn?

Rosalyn OPENS her mouth, letting out...

INT. CARLOS'S ROOM - NIGHT

A SCREAM!

Carlos immediately JUMPS awake. The screams come from the room next to his. He rushes out of his bed.

INT. MERCEDES ROOM - NIGHT

Carlos BURSTS the door open. He looks confused. Mercedes peacefully sleeps in her bed.

He takes a moment to compose himself before exiting the room without making any noise.

INT. HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS

SILVIA (O.C.)
Carlos?

Carlos skips a beat, caught by surprise. Silvia stands beside him in the dark hallway.

SILVIA (CONT'D)
Is she gonna be ok?

Carlos just stares at her, confused. Is he dreaming?

CARLOS
Yes. She will.

With that, Silvia simply turns around and marches back to her room. What the fuck was that?

INT. RÓMINA'S ROOM - NIGHT

Sitting in a dark room illuminated by the dim light of candles, Rómina pours some tea into a cup.

She then pours it again on another cup, and another hand grabs it. This is CELESTE (30). The two women drink in silence.

The room door creeks open, and a silhouette comes in and sits next to them.

Rómina grabs another cup and pours some more tea. The silhouette grabs it. It's Marta.

INT. HOTEL'S KITCHEN - DAY

Alberto plods in to find Mercedes having breakfast alone. Their gaze meet, but Alberto quickly looks away.

He walks to the small buffet. Not many options these days, so he serves some cereal. He looks back at Mercedes who has her back turned to him.

Alberto shilly-shallies before sitting next to her.

A long beat.

MERCEDES
Do you remember what you said yesterday? About me not caring for Dad?

ALBERTO
I didn't mean it.

MERCEDES
No, it was true. My dad just died, and the only thing I can think about is how I'll never find out anything about my mom. I can't stop thinking about it ever since Rómina told me he died. He was the only person that could've given me that information but he never did...and I think I hate him for it.

ALBERTO
I sometimes wish I could hate him more...it would be less painful.

Alberto laughs, sadly.

ALBERTO (CONT'D)
After everything he did--cutting us off, sending me away to live with my alcoholic mother, not checking on me when I went to rehab, not calling when Thomas was born...even after everything, I somehow still care.

Beat.

MERCEDES
Sometimes happy memories overshadow dark ones. It can be a pain in the ass, but it can also be a blessing.

She grabs Alberto's hand. He smiles.

MERCEDES (CONT'D)
Sometimes I wish I could go back to the times before that summer.

Something clicks in Alberto's head.

ALBERTO
Maybe we can.

Mercedes observes him with interest.

INT. HOTEL'S LIBRARY - DAY

Alone in the sunlit room sits Silvia. She attentively draws a direct copy of an old painting of the Hotel in her notebook. In this version, the sun shines brighter, the grass appears greener and the flowers fully bloom.

Carlos comes in and slowly approaches her. He analyzes her drawing.

CARLOS
Wow, did you paint it yourself?

He sits on the floor in front of her.

SILVIA
Um-hum.

CARLOS
It looks amazing.

She smiles, shyly.

SILVIA
I want to be an artist when I grow up, but mommy says it's not a real job.

CARLOS
Does she?

Carlos lowers his voice.

CARLOS (CONT'D)
Can I tell you a secret?

This sparks her interest.

CARLOS (CONT'D)
I wanted to be an artist too. A musician. Different type but still an artist.

SILVIA
Why didn't you?

CARLOS
My mom also didn't think it was a real job. I also wasn't talented but that's not the point.

She laughs.

CARLOS (CONT'D)
But you are. And I think it's a great job for talented people.

They smile at each other warmly.

CARLOS (CONT'D)
Can you draw me?

She analyses his face.

SILVIA
I never drew people before, but I could try.

Silvia goes to a blank page in her notebook and starts drawing Carlos, who now sits still.

CARLOS
Silvia, last night...

She keeps drawing.

CARLOS (CONT'D)
Did you hear it? Mercedes' screams?

Silvia stops. Her expression shifts. She appears mature.

SILVIA
I did.

A beat.

CARLOS
What were you doing--

RÓMINA (O.C.)
There you are.

Rómina rushes into the library, interrupting their conversation.

SILVIA
Look, mom!

Silvia stands and runs to her mother with her notebook in hand. Carlos hides his frustration with a smile.

EXT. HOTEL - PAST - NIGHT

Marta walks cautiously towards the hotel's gates. All the lights are off, making the stars above shimmer even more brightly.

She quietly steps inside the property. As she prepares to close the metal door behind her, the wind suddenly BLOWS tempestuously--

BANG! The gate SLAMS.

Marta shuts her eyes trembling, waiting for something to happen. But nothing does.

She gathers some courage and opens them, turning to face the hotel. The lights are still off. She lets out a sigh of relief.

Marta starts to make her way toward it when--

JOSE (O.C.)
You're back!

She freezes. Her face filled with terror. She swallows dry.

MARTA
Yeah. It was such a nice day today I--

Marta looks back at JOSE and smiles.

MARTA (CONT'D)
I figured I could just go for a walk.

JOSE
And you didn't bother to let me know?

MARTA
I assumed since it was my day off I could've...

Jose's intimidating gaze penetrates her. She stops talking.

MARTA (CONT'D)
Sorry. It won't happen again.

JOSE
I hope not.

He opens a smile.

JOSE (CONT'D)
You're right. It was such a nice day today and the night reflects that. Do you mind joining me for a walk?

His tone suggests that this is more of an order than a request.

MARTA
S-sure.

Marta paces in his direction.

INT. HOTEL'S ATTIC - DAY

The dust and spider webs suggest that the room hasn't been cleaned in years.

Alberto looks for something amongst many pilled boxes. Mercedes wanders around.

MERCEDES
How the fuck did you know this place existed?

ALBERTO
'Cuz I was a noisy kid. Here.

Alberto grabs a small box with a big red "X" drawn on it.

He places it in the middle of the room and opens it. Mercedes approaches with curiosity.

Inside, they find piles and piles of old Polaroids. Mercedes takes one of the photos out.

It's Jose, holding a baby.

MERCEDES
Aww is this you?

ALBERTO
No, that's Carlos. This is me.

He shows her another photo of him and Jose playing by the lake.

ALBERTO (CONT'D)
And there's you.

Alberto hands her a photo and continues to search the box. Mercedes examines it.

She's about five years old, posing in a fairy Halloween costume. But there is something else... She frowns.

A woman wearing a white dress stares back at her from afar.

ALBERTO (O.C.) (CONT'D)
Most of them are landscapes, but I'm sure we can find some more in other boxes--

MERCEDES
Look.

Alberto looks up. She shows him the photo and points at the woman.

MERCEDES (CONT'D)
Do you remember her? She was a guest the last summer we were here.

ALBERTO
I don't think I do.

MERCEDES
This photo was taken years before that summer.

ALBERTO
Maybe she was a regular guest.

MERCEDES
Maybe.

She places the photo in her back pocket and starts searching the box for more.

MERCEDES (CONT'D)
Do you think maybe we can find something about my mom here? Maybe documents?

ALBERTO
Here?

MERCEDES
Yes.

ALBERTO
I don't know. I--

He looks at her hopeful expression.

ALBERTO (CONT'D)
I don't want you to get your hopes too high.

MERCEDES
You're right. Even if there was, it would take ages to find.

Her excitement fades away. Alberto feels guilty.

ALBERTO
Glad we have all the time in the world before the funeral.

MERCEDES
We?

ALBERTO
This is a two-person job, isn't it?

She smiles at him tenderly. He pretends not to see it and keeps searching the box.

INT. CARLOS'S ROOM - DAY

KNOCK! KNOCK!

Carlos finishes getting dressed.

CARLOS
Yeah?

No response. Suddenly, a piece of paper slides from under the door.

He rushes to it and grabs it. His face grows pale.

Carlos quickly opens the door. No one stands on the other side. He shuts it and stares at the piece of paper again.

EXT. TOWN’S LIBRARY - DAY

Carlos sprints to the old town’s library. It once was glorious, but now appears to be falling apart.

INT. TOWN'S LIBRARY - DAY

The library is empty. Carlos approaches an OLD MAN, who sits at the counter reading a book.

CARLOS
Hi, excuse me.

The old man looks up, annoyed.

CARLOS (CONT’D)
Where can I find the town’s criminal archives?

The old man points to the back of the library.

INT. TOWN'S LIBRARY - DAY

Carlos scrolls through files of missing kids over the years. He searches for “Rosalyn”. Nothing. He tries a different spelling. Nothing.

He contemplates. Hesitant, he types “Jose Mendes”. His shaking hands click on search.

Loading...

A bunch of articles pop up with headlines such as “The Curse of the Hotel on the Hill”, and “Haunted Forrest”. Below them, are photos of Jose and the hotel next to names of guests who had disappeared over the years.

Carlos scrolls down to the first article ever written about the subject and sees the photo of a young woman next to a photo of Jose. It's Marta. But that means nothing to Carlos. He looks for the name of who wrote the article.

"Alice Parker".

He scrolls up again and notices that almost all of the articles were written by Alice.

Carlos grabs a phone book and starts looking for a name.

EXT. ALICE'S HOME - DAY

Carlos parks in front of an old, small country house. He examines it, before stepping out of the car.

He sashays to the front door and rings the bell. He hears footsteps approaching.

ALICE PARKER (late 40s) opens the door. The two stare at each other for a second.

CARLOS
Mrs. Parker--

ALICE
Alice.

CARLOS
Alice. I'm Carlos, we just spoke on the phone.

ALICE
Oh yes, yes. Please come in.

CARLOS
Thank you for agreeing to talk with me.

ALICE
Of course.

She lets him in and closes the door behind her.

INT. ALICE'S HOUSE - CONTINUOUS

The house feels like it is stuck in the 80s. Its eccentric decoration gives it a unique and welcoming feeling.

ALICE
It's always a pleasure to talk about my work.

CARLOS
Actually, I'm here to talk about a specific subject of your articles.

Carlos sits down on the couch. Alice sits in front of him.

CARLOS (CONT'D)
Does the name "Jose Mendes" ring a bell?

Alice's face immediately darkens.

ALICE
Of course, it does. Is this about his suicide?

CARLOS
No, it's...

He struggles to find the right words.

CARLOS (CONT'D)
I'm Jose Mendes' son--

Alice immediately stands up, in shock.

ALICE
Leave.

CARLOS
I--

ALICE
Leave this house immediately or I'll call the police.

CARLOS
I'm investigating the disappearance of a little girl, and I think my dad might've been involved--

ALICE
I don't care. No one related to that demon is welcome in my house.

CARLOS
But--

ALICE
LEAVE!

Carlos stands up and rushes out of the house.

EXT. ALICE'S HOUSE - CONTINUOUS

He speeds towards his car. Alice follows him outside but stays behind on the front porch.

ALICE
I hope Jose and that hotel burn in hell.

Carlos enters the car and drives away. Alice watches the car disappear into the horizon.

Once he's gone, she breaks down crying.

INT. HOTEL'S LIBRARY - NIGHT

Carlos drags his feet into the library. Inside, he finds Alberto and Mercedes laughing as they exchange photographs from the box.

Mercedes notices Carlos.

MERCEDES
Someone's in a huff.

CARLOS
I just had a bad afternoon.

MERCEDES
Did you go to town?

Carlos nods.

ALBERTO
Maybe that's why.

MERCEDES
This will cheer you up.

Carlos walks over to them and Mercedes hands him a photo. It's the three of them as kids by a campfire.

CARLOS
Oh my God, I remember this day. It was the last time Dad took us camping up the mountain. Where did you find this?

MERCEDES
Apparently, Dad had a secret attic where he kept all this stuff.

CARLOS
Does he have more?

INT. ATTIC - NIGHT

The three siblings walk up the stairs to the attic.

MERCEDES
I was thinking, maybe we could make an album with all--

She stops talking as they step into the attic.

It's empty.

Carlos seems confused as he watches his sibling bewilderedly facing the empty room.

CARLOS
What's wrong?

ALBERTO
(Whispering) She took it.

CARLOS
What?

ALBERTO
SHE TOOK IT.

Alberto storms out of the room.

MERCEDES
For fuck's sake.

Mercedes follows Alberto down. Carlos stands in the empty room for a few seconds before going after them.

INT. SILVIA'S ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Alberto STORMS into the room, followed by Mercedes.

Inside, Rómina combs Silvia's hair. She doesn't even flinch at their sudden entrance and just calmly stares back. Silvia does the same, but she looks puzzled.

ALBERTO
Where did you put them?

RÓMINA
Put what?

Carlos appears from behind Mercedes and gestures for Silvia to meet him. Rómina gives her a nod and she rushes toward her brother.

ALBERTO
You know exactly what I'm talking about. The boxes that were in the attic.

RÓMINA
I didn't touch any boxes.

Alberto laughs incredulously. He could punch something.

MERCEDES
Just tell us where you put them, Rómina. Please.

Rómina seems surprised that Mercedes joined in. She remains silent.

ALBERTO
I just don't understand why would you take it. Was there something there that you didn't want us to find?

RÓMINA
What is that supposed to mean?

ALBERTO
Why didn't you tell us that Dad got shot?

Carlos grabs Silvia's hand and walks her out of the room. Mercedes seems conflicted but does not say anything.

RÓMINA
Your father was going through a difficult time.

ALBERTO
No.

RÓMINA
He has been struggling for years--

ALBERTO (CONT'D)
That's not what I asked...

ALBERTO (CONT'D)
That's not what I FUCKING asked.

Rómina stops talking.

ALBERTO (CONT'D)
I asked WHY didn't you tell us that he got shot? Why would you let us go see his body to find a FUCKING bullet in his brain?

RÓMINA
It wasn't in my place to do so.

ALBERTO
Yeah sure, it wasn't in your place. As if that ever stopped you from doing anything.

Beat. Alberto lowers his voice.

ALBERTO (CONT'D)
Did you do it?

RÓMINA
What?

ALBERTO
Did you kill him?

MERCEDES
Alberto please.

RÓMINA
How dare you?

RÓMINA (CONT'D)
I LOVED your father.

ALBERTO
Sure you did. Loved his money even more.

Rómina gets closer to Alberto.

RÓMINA
You haven't changed at all since the day I first met you. You always have to make everything about yourself but be careless about those around you. You complain about your father never going after you but you never even bothered to call because you were too proud to do so. I was the only one by his side all these years, powerlessly watching him as he slowly died along with this place.
(MORE)

RÓMINA (CONT'D)
This piece of TRASH that you accuse me of wanting hasn't made a penny in years. The money you think I'm after does not even exist. That is why Jose put a bullet in his head, because of this FUCKING place. The same place you think everyone wants a piece of, this HELL was the reason for his downfall. And you dare to come back now, all these years later, and judge me? YOU? The sole reason why Jose felt like he failed as a father?

Their eye contact feels intense. In the corner of her mouth, Alberto sees almost a smirk.

RÓMINA (CONT'D)
Tell me Alberto, how did it feel like?

Terror fills his face. She knows.

ALBERTO
Shut up.

RÓMINA
How does it feel to carry the guilt all these years? Maybe the drugs helped...

ALBERTO
Screw you.

Alberto rushes out of the room, fighting his tears.

Mercedes just stands there in shock. She has never seen that side of Rómina before.

MERCEDES
How dare you?

She turns around to go after Alberto.

RÓMINA
I know what you want.

Mercedes stops.

RÓMINA (CONT'D)
Victoria.

MERCEDES
Excuse me?

RÓMINA
Her name was Victoria.

Beat.

MERCEDES
How do you know that?

RÓMINA
I'm not your enemy Mercedes. I wanna help you. Allow me to help you.

INT. ALBERTO'S ROOM - NIGHT

Alberto frantically stuffs his clothes into a suitcase. Carlos stands at the door watching him, as Mercedes walks in.

MERCEDES
What are you doing?

ALBERTO
What does it look like that I'm doing?

CARLOS
He's leaving.

MERCEDES
Now?

CARLOS
That was my reaction.

ALBERTO
You don't expect me to stay another night after what she said.

MERCEDES
Well, you accused her of killing Dad--

ALBERTO
Are you taking her side?

MERCEDES
Of course not. I'm just--

ALBERTO
Good.

MERCEDES
I just think you're being a little...

CARLOS
Impulsive.

MERCEDES
That's all.

Alberto doesn't stop packing.

MERCEDES (CONT'D)
Alberto! Are you even listening? Dad's funeral is in a few days.

ALBERTO
He wouldn't want his biggest disappointment present so--

MERCEDES
Rómina knows about my mom.

This makes Alberto stop.

MERCEDES (CONT'D)
She knows her name. She said she could help me find out more about her.

ALBERTO
How do you know she's not bluffing?

MERCEDES
Why would she? I mean, she knows her name.

ALBERTO
Dad must've mentioned it to her.

MERCEDES
So it means he probably told Rómina more stuff about her. He never even told me her name, I had to find that out by myself.

CARLOS
Do you think she's telling the truth?

MERCEDES
I don't know. It doesn't hurt to try and figure it out.
(MORE)

MERCEDES (CONT'D)
I mean, this is the best chance I have of finding out the truth.

ALBERTO
Fuck me. So are you staying?

MERCEDES
I have to try.

ALBERTO
Just...don't get your hopes too high. You know how it went last time.

MERCEDES
I know.

Alberto pushes his suitcase aside and takes a deep breath.

ALBERTO
I guess I can go to another hotel in the morning.

MERCEDES
So are you staying in Maine for the funeral?

ALBERTO
I guess. You'll need a ride back to Rhode Island.

Mercedes smiles. The three stay silent for a few seconds.

CARLOS
Do you guys remember Rosalyn?

MERCEDES
Who?

CARLOS
My imaginary friend.

The two nod in agreement.

CARLOS (CONT'D)
I don't think she was imaginary.

MERCEDES
What?

Carlos takes out a piece of paper from his pocket and unfolds it. He holds it straight for them to see.

It’s a drawing of what appears to be young Carlos, playing happily with Rosalyn.

CARLOS
Silvia made this.

ALBERTO
And?

CARLOS
This is me. And this is Rosalyn.

Alberto takes the drawing and analyses it.

MERCEDES
How is that possible? Even if she was real, she would be around your age now.

CARLOS
Exactly. And Rosalyn disappeared years ago. I mean, I assume she did. One night we were playing hide and seek and since then she never showed up again.

MERCEDES
If she’s real, do you think something happened to her?

Carlos contemplates.

CARLOS
I don’t know. Or maybe this is someone else, I don’t know. This is stupid.

He takes the drawing back. Alberto changes the subject.

ALBERTO
I’m gonna finish packing.

MERCEDES
Here, I’ll help you.

Carlos folds the drawing and puts it in his pocket again.

EXT. LAKE - PAST - NIGHT

Footsteps in the mud. The night is serene, with all its familiar sounds.

Jose leads the way, while Marta follows nervously.

MARTA
I'm sorry I didn't tell you I was going out earlier.

JOSE
Victoria told me.

MARTA
She did?

JOSE
Um-hum. You two had grown quite close I see.

MARTA
It's nice to have someone close to my age to talk to.

JOSE
She also told me you were planning to leave.

This catches Marta by surprise. She doesn't say anything. Jose does not look back or stop walking.

JOSE (CONT'D)
Is that right?

MARTA
I-I'm not--

JOSE
Oh, relax dear. I don't expect you to be a nanny forever.

She looks back. They are deep into the garden now.

INT. LIBRARY - NIGHT

From the outside point of view through the ajar door, Mercedes is being watched. Inside, she seals the box with photos.

CREEK...

Mercedes looks back at the door, alarmed. The door is now wide open.

MERCEDES
Hello?

A beat.

A woman's SILHOUETTE flashes past the door. Mercedes stands up.

MERCEDES (CONT'D)
Rómina?

Mercedes rushes after it.

INT. HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS

Mercedes steps out and catches a glimpse of the silhouette rushing out of the front door of the hotel.

She follows it.

INT. ALBERTO'S ROOM - SAME TIME

Alberto prepares to get into bed when something catches his attention through the window.

Almost imperceptible in the fog stands Marta. He blinks twice. It couldn't be the girl from the bar--

BANG! Carlos storms in.

Alberto looks back startled.

CARLOS
I can't find Mercedes.

Alberto does not think twice. He follows Carlos out of the room.

EXT. LAKE - PAST - NIGHT

Marta and Jose stand side by side in front of the lake. The water reflects the moonlight, illuminating their faces. He looks calm but she is visibly anxious.

JOSE
You know why I hired you, Marta?

Marta shakes her head.

JOSE (CONT'D)
I don't trust these town folks. Always wandering around, trying to get into my business. But you know, I knew it was a risk I was taking by moving here.
(MORE)

JOSE (CONT'D)
Small town, conservative values...they don't usually trust outsiders, especially foreigners like me. Or you.

Beat.

JOSE (CONT'D)
It was a little selfish of me I admit, to hire you thinking I would have you all to myself... you know, doing your job.

MARTA
I didn't--

JOSE
Don't interrupt me.

His tone shifts. It's darker.

JOSE (CONT'D)
Imagine my surprise when I found out the town folks were using you as a Trojan horse.

Marta tries to step away but Jose grabs her arm, firmly.

MARTA
Please let me go, Jose. I swear I will disappear and you'll never hear from me again.

JOSE
What do you think the Trojans would've done if they knew beforehand that the Greeks were inside the horse?

Marta starts crying.

JOSE (CONT'D)
Burn it maybe?

MARTA
HELP--

EXT. GARDEN - "SAME TIME"

AAAAH!

Mercedes POV: Her attention turns to the screams. She looks in the opposite direction and sees the silhouette disappearing in the fog. She hesitates but runs toward the screams instead.

MATCH CUT WITH:

Same scene, real POV: Mercedes's eyes are closed. Instead of running, she walks slowly and aimlessly toward the screams. She's sleepwalking.

EXT. LAKE - PAST - SAME TIME

Jose GRABS Marta's neck. With all of his strength, he pulls her head underwater.

Her screams are muffled. She struggles, but his grip is too strong. It's useless.

INT. HOTEL - NIGHT

Carlos and Alberto wander around the hotel hallways.

CARLOS
(Calling out) Mercedes?

ALBERTO
Do you think she's sleepwalking again?

The wind blows softly, revealing the front door open. They exchange a glance before stepping out.

EXT. LAKE - NIGHT

Mercedes POV: She sprints toward the lake. She looks around confused. The screams have ceased.

The fog begins to disperse. She looks at the lake and spots something floating.

It's a body. Marta.

Mercedes's eyes widen. Without giving it a second thought, she takes her shoes off and jumps, swimming towards her.

MATCH CUT WITH:

Real POV: Mercedes slowly enters the lake and starts to float. She opens her eyes and looks at the sky. Slowly, she starts to sink.

The sounds of the night are now inaudible, muffled by the gurgling of the water. The moon looks further and further away now, its light more distorted. Her eyes start to close again...

SPLASH!

She hears the sound of someone diving into the water and swimming in her direction. Just before she closes her eyes, she sees Carlos.

EXT. LAKE - CONTINUOUS

Carlos EMERGES out of the water, holding Mercedes with one arm.

Alberto helps them out of the water. They place Mercedes on the ground.

She’s not moving.

ALBERTO
Move.

Alberto pushes Carlos aside and starts doing CPR on her.

ALBERTO (CONT’D)
Twelve, thirteen, Fourteen--

He breathes into her mouth. Not responsive. He continues.

CUT TO:

INT. MERCEDES ROOM - PAST - NIGHT

Same as the last scene from the beginning of the episode. Young Mercedes slowly makes her way to the window and looks outside.

A WOMAN stands with her back turned to Mercedes. This time, she wears a white dress instead of a red one. The woman slowly turns to face Mercedes with her striking brown eyes. Her skin is dark and healthy, and there is a warmth to her.

It’s the same woman from the photo.

She opens a longing smile.

WOMAN
Mercedes.

CUT TO:

EXT. LAKE - NIGHT

Mercedes’s eyes OPEN as she GASPS.

CUT TO BLACK.

END OF PILOT